



Language and Literacy Practice Support

Kindergarten Learning
Progression Toolkit

DELIVERING
FOR QUEENSLAND



Queensland
Government

Supporting reconciliation

Acknowledgement of Country

We acknowledge the Traditional Owners of the lands, seas, skies and waterways from across Queensland.

We pay our respect to the Elders past and present, for they hold the memories, traditions, the culture and hopes of Aboriginal peoples and Torres Strait Islander peoples.

A better understanding and respect for Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander cultures develops an enriched appreciation of Australia's cultural heritage and can lead to reconciliation.

This is essential to the maturity of Australia as a nation and fundamental to the development of an Australian identity.



Produced by:

Department of Education, Queensland

Copyright notice

© State of Queensland (Department of Education) 2026 unless indicated otherwise. All rights reserved.

Copyright in this publication is owned by or licensed to the State of Queensland (acting through the Department of Education). No part may be reproduced, communicated, modified or stored by any process without the written permission of the Department of Education. All rights reserved.

This publication is not part of NEALS.

Copyright in this publication is owned by or licensed to the State of Queensland (acting through the Department of Education). No part may be reproduced, communicated, modified or stored by any process without the written permission of the Department of Education. All rights reserved.

Written requests for permission should be addressed to the:

Copyright Unit

Information Management

Department of Education

PO Box 15033, City East QLD 4002

Third-party copyright material

This publication includes third-party content from the Kindergarten Learning Progression – Language and literacy, developed by the Australian Council for Educational Research Ltd (ACER) for the Queensland Department of Education.

© 2023 Australian Council for Educational Research Ltd 19 Prospect Hill Road, Camberwell VIC 3124

www.acer.org

Licence pending. For further information, contact: permissions@acer.org

Disclaimer statement

While all care has been taken in preparing this publication, the State of Queensland (acting through the Department of Education) does not warrant that the content is complete, accurate or current. The Department of Education, expressly disclaims any liability for any damage resulting from the use of the material contained in this publication and will not be responsible for any loss, howsoever arising, from use of, or reliance on this material. The user must make the enquiries relevant to their use in relation to the material available in this publication.

Every effort has been made to trace and acknowledge copyright. The Department of Education would be pleased to hear from the copyright holder to rectify any omission or error.

Intentional decision-making to support children's language and literacy

This resource highlights the importance of intentional decision-making in supporting children's language and literacy development. Strong language skills enable children to express themselves, understand others, and build a foundation for reading and writing. It also highlights the value of recognising and preserving Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander languages, such as Creole, Kriol, and Yumpla Tok, celebrating linguistic diversity and children's ability to code-switch.

The Early Years Learning Framework (EYLF V2.0, 2022) highlights that "children's use of their home languages underpins their sense of identity and their conceptual development. Children's sense of belonging is strengthened when their language, interaction styles and ways of communicating are valued. They have the right to be continuing users of their home language, as well as to develop competency in Standard Australian English" (p. 57).

The EYLF learning outcomes and the Queensland kindergarten learning guideline (QKLG) learning and development areas promote and support children's ongoing learning progress in Language and Literacy related skills; Sounds and Speech and Comprehension. They promote the development of responsive kindergarten programs through intentional decision-making.

Strengthening Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander perspectives

Consideration of Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander world views is vital to embedding and strengthening Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander perspectives. It acknowledges the diversity of Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander culture, traditions, languages, historical impacts, and provides teachers and educators with contextualised awareness of protocols of the lands that they are working on.

'Educators think deeply and seek assistance where possible, through engaging with Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander people, about how to embed Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander perspectives in the philosophy of the setting, their planning and implementation of curriculum' (EYLF V2.0, 2022, p. 6)

The intentional teaching strategies and learning experiences align with:

Early Years Learning Framework (EYLF) learning outcomes:

- Children have a strong sense of identity
- Children are connected with and contribute to their world
- Children are effective communicators

Principles:

- Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander perspectives
- Cultural responsiveness

NOTE: Connections to the EYLF and QKLG are a starting point and may vary across intentional teaching strategies and learning experiences in different contexts.

Queensland kindergarten learning guideline (QKLG) – Learning and development areas:

- Identity
- Connectedness
- Communicating

Principles:

- High expectations, equity and respect for diversity
- Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander Perspectives
- Sustainability
- Creative inclusive learning environments

Sounds and speech – Intentional teaching strategies

Partnering	• Build strong relationships with children and families to understand and value their home languages. • Talk one-on-one with families, outside where possible, during orientation and transition sessions. Use enrolment forms to gather insights about home languages and cultural backgrounds. • Take time to build genuine connection with each family. • Attend community events to build relationships informally with the community e.g., attend local cultural events, offer support with some of the activities or even hold a stall to promote your service. • Connect and collaborate with local Elders and Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander community. How could they help translate familiar songs into language e.g., Heads, Shoulders, Knees and Toes.	Explaining	• Link new ideas to what children already know about sounds and speech. • Give clear examples to build awareness of how sounds make words. • Talk about ways we care for Country, linking sounds to the land, water, and animals. • Go outside and listen quietly to nature. Ask children what sounds they can hear.
Identifying	• Draw children's attention to new ideas or topics, to capture their interest and encourage exploration. • Point out interesting objects, new vocabulary, language patterns, sounds, symbols or visual images to spark their curiosity as they start to 'read' their environment. • Highlight the syllables in words by clapping them out or breaking words into chunks.	Encouraging	• Create opportunities for children to actively engage in language and literacy. • Tailor experiences to children's interests and learning needs to build confidence and enjoyment. • Encourage children to use their home language and value their ability to code switch. • When recording children's stories, celebrate their unique ways of communicating. Remember, for some children, Standard Australian English may be their third or fourth language.
Making connections	• Connect with local language speakers and knowledge holders to celebrate and share language through songs, rhymes, and oral storytelling. • Use yarning circles to invite children to share family names, stories and community connections. • Provide shared experiences that make speech and sound practice meaningful and connected to place and people. • Help children understand relationships in sounds and speech and how these elements form the basis of communication. • Guide children in comparing similar sounds, recognising initial letters and exploring the various purposes language serves.	Listening	• Create meaningful moments for sustained interaction. Listen deeply to what children communicate through words, gestures, movement, art, symbols, dance, or music. • Encourage active listening to help children notice and tell the difference between sounds in spoken language. • Read books that invite children to listen and respond with sounds from nature e.g., animal noises or weather sounds. • Be mindful of cultural differences in listening. In some cultures, direct eye contact with a speaker is not appropriate. • Listen, understand and celebrate children's home languages. Some Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander children may use different sounds or pronunciations than Standard Australian English. This is not a deficit; it shows strength in bilingualism and code-switching.
		Modelling	• Demonstrate correct language use, effective listening behaviours and constructive back-and-forth exchanges. • Model different ways to communicate, verbally and non-verbally, and how to respond in back-and-forth conversations.

Sounds and speech – Learning experiences

Working together	- Introduce traditional games that require children to work together and take turns. - Embed cultural values of Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander people sharing and collaboration in group experiences, such as traditional group games. - Embed a culturally safe environment where children share and collaboratively learn together, practicing turn-taking and deep listening.	Sensory exploration	- Give children chances to explore books in interactive, sensory ways. - Offer books with flaps, textures, sounds or simple labels, and invite children to make their own sensory book. - Provide multimodal texts and reading activities that encourage engagement with different textures and features. - Extend learning outdoors by letting children describe sensory experiences, like rough bark, smooth rocks, sand or slime.
Hands on activities	- Engage children in cooking traditional foods, encouraging them to follow picture-based recipes and follow instructions. Talk about ingredients, build vocabulary and comprehension. - Learn and explore traditional and contemporary songs and stories that incorporate home and community language, including dance and rhythm.	Story time	- Engage children in small group or one-on-one story time. Children love to make connection to their world views and their real life. - Highlight new vocabulary and interesting details, explain unfamiliar words, and ask questions to stimulate curiosity. - Model pronunciation, sentence structure, and expressive reading techniques. - Explore different genres to broaden their interests and understanding. - Encourage some visual learning by inviting children to tell the story of the book just by looking at the pictures. - When reading a book, pause and invite the children to finish the sentence or guess what is next. - Give older children the opportunity to read with the younger children - Explore concepts of rhyme and repetition. Develop a word bank of new words and vocabulary.
Storytelling	- Embed traditional oral storytelling, including songs and model planning, organisation, and decision-making skills. - Use picture books to discuss characters and challenges, asking questions to build comprehension. - Encourage children to retell stories in their own words, using props, artifacts, small world play, puppets or other visual aids e.g., felt pieces. - Label objects in illustrations to expand vocabulary and support word-meaning connections. - Capture children's storytelling, including home language and involve families or community for support. - Include cultural stories about sharing and Caring for Country, allowing children to become authors and illustrators of their own stories. - Invite children to share stories about their family and community through drawing or other visual documentation.	Beats in words	- During group time, invite children to clap out the syllables in their names (e.g., Lu-cy – clap, clap). Celebrate different pronunciations, including home languages. - Fill a bag with familiar objects and have children pull one out, clapping or moving to match the syllables. - Explore multiple ways to represent syllables: clapping sticks, stomping feet, tapping knees or jumping. Connect movements to traditional songs or dances where possible to embed cultural rhythms and storytelling. - Invite children to recognise and play with the sounds and words of different languages they encounter in their environment.
Yarning and expressing ideas and opinions	- Invite children to discuss familiar stories or texts and give a simple reason for their opinions. - Encourage children to yarn about the story, linking ideas to personal experiences to build critical thinking and communication skills. - Invite Elders or community members to share a story, and with permission, record it to revisit later.		

Comprehension – Intentional teaching strategies

Deeper Learnings	• Use local language resources and community oral stories to strengthen children's connection to culture and history. • Identify the Traditional Custodians of the land on which you work and build respectful relationships with Elders and community members. • Allocate funds to recognise their time and knowledge. • Introduce tools like the AIATSIS map to help children link their special places with different tribal areas. • Offer multimodal resources e.g., songs, stories and visuals that include home and community languages to deepen understanding of local history and culture.	Negotiating • Help children explore different perspectives in texts to understand and evaluate information. • Discuss ideas and viewpoints, encouraging children to think critically about what they read. • Introduce negotiating gently, supporting children to share their opinions in ways that respect their confidence, culture and communication style.
Identifying	• Highlight new ideas and topics to spark curiosity and investigation, helping children retell and interpret information. • Encourage them to share stories in their home language and connect content to their local experiences, e.g., comparing how they call family members (Grandma, Aka, Mum, Mummy). • Use traditional songs and nursery rhymes to introduce new concepts and language, supporting comprehension. • Create a culturally rich environment where children learn through respectful and meaningful engagement with space, stories, and language.	Questioning • Use open-ended questions to encourage children to reflect on the sounds they hear and the words they are learning. This is an effective strategy for promoting critical thinking and deeper engagement with sounds and speech. • Encourage children to discuss and analyse sounds and speech through questioning. This enhances their phonological awareness and comprehension skills. • Children may communicate and understand the world in ways that reflect their culture, which can differ from Standard Australian English (SAE).
Negotiating	• Help children explore different perspectives in texts to understand and evaluate information. • Discuss ideas and viewpoints, encouraging children to think critically about what they read. • Introduce negotiating gently, supporting children to share their opinions in ways that respect their confidence, culture and communication style.	
Making connections	• Support children to link new ideas to their own experiences, helping them understand relationships between concepts. • Model how to compare experiences and ideas e.g., after reading a story about seasonal changes, discuss how the children's own observations of Country are similar or different (flowering plants, bird calls or local weather patterns). • Encourage children to share their own examples and observations, including family stories or local knowledge, to strengthen comprehension, interpretation and connection to Country.	



Comprehension – Learning experiences

Traditional games	- Use traditional games that involve planning, following rules, and thinking through steps. - Discuss the strategies and choices players make during the game to build understanding. - Follow cultural protocols; check who can teach games from other Countries and where possible, consult with Elders or knowledge holders.	Interactive Stories	- Use story aprons or felt boards to make storytelling playful and interactive. Invite children to add pieces, retell stories, or create new scenes using local stories or symbols from Country. - Encourage back-and-forth storytelling to build vocabulary, language patterns, creativity, and cultural connection.
Connection with Country	- Take children outside to explore nature and engage their senses through touch, sound, and observation. - Plant, water, and care for a bush tucker garden, connecting children with the land and its cycles. - Explore local seasonal changes and Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander ways of observing nature, such as noticing animal signals e.g., Black cockatoos coming can mean a storm coming. - Encourage children to feel the country beneath their feet by going barefoot and noticing textures of soil, grass, sand and leaves. - Co-create outdoor sensory experiences with children and families to explore the environment, notice seasonal changes, and strengthen cultural connections to Country. - Talk about local place names and include these in your shared Acknowledgement to Country to deepen understanding, connection and immersion.	Sound walk	- Take children to listen to Country outdoors. Introduce 'Walking on Country' concepts. Ask them what animals they can hear, what sounds in nature they can detect e.g., footsteps crunching leaves on the ground. - Incorporate cultural musical instruments such as clapsticks and kulaps. - As they explore, encourage them to remember different sounds they hear. - After the walk, discuss the sounds they found and engage them in a conversation about their experiences. - Consider next steps in learning e.g., recording and documenting the bird sounds, investigate birds' common to the area.
Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander Art	- Explore local Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander art, discussing the meaning, symbols and cultural significance in each piece. - Use clay and natural materials to create art, linking to the concept of Caring for Country and returning materials to the land after use. - Learn about the region's local art through Elders or community knowledge holders, connecting children's work to place and culture. - Discuss contemporary and traditional art, exploring what the art communicates and encouraging children to explain their understanding.	Letter Sound Play	- Create sensory baskets with objects that start with specific letter sounds e.g., /s/: spoon, sock, snake. - Label each bin and encourage children to explore, identify sounds and connect them to letters or their own names. - Offer a variety of sound activities such as songs, stories or games to reinforce letter sounds in a play-based way. - Connect to Country by using natural materials e.g., clapsticks, bark or sand for children to explore sounds and textures, - Invite children to describe what they feel and hear.
"I wonder" questions	- Ask open-ended questions like "I wonder why..." or "What happens next?" to spark curiosity and critical thinking. - Give children time to respond and allow them to share understanding in ways that feel comfortable, including nonverbal responses. - Respect that some children may not be used to open-ended questions and may need extra time to think. - Encourage connections to their own experiences, knowledge, and ways of being.	Sound stories	- Invite children to create their own stories using sound effects for characters, animals or weather. - Use a simple story prompt or picture book for inspiration. - Encourage children to listen to Country and notice natural sounds around them. - Encourage children to notice and explore the sounds and words from languages spoken at home and in the community.
		Rhyme time	- Use nursery rhymes and songs to build children's sense of rhythm, rhyme and pronunciation while supporting memory and cooperation through group singing. - Include songs from diverse cultures and, where appropriate, translate familiar rhymes into local Aboriginal or Torres Strait Islander languages with community guidance and permission. - Provide opportunities for children to hear and use words from languages other than English in their play and songs.